

COLLAPSE OF THE SOVIET UNION

THE RAPID DISINTEGRATION OF THE SOVIET STATE SHOCKED THE WORLD

In March 1985, Mikhail Gorbachev became leader of a stagnating Soviet Union. He realized that the Soviet Bloc needed radical reforms, and tried to modernize socialism. The result was the total disintegration of the USSR, which transformed the map of Europe and brought about a new world order.

Mikhail Gorbachev was a popular choice for leader. He introduced two new concepts, *glasnost* and *perestroika*—"openness" and "restructuring"—and championed a more liberal, dynamic society. Although Gorbachev's popularity was affirmed when he withdrew troops from Afghanistan, non-Russian minority groups throughout the USSR agitated for independence. In July 1989, Gorbachev announced that countries within the Warsaw Pact (see 1955) could determine their own futures in openly contested elections.

East and Central Europe responded to Gorbachev's greater freedoms: in 1989 Poland elected to end communist rule; Hungary opened its borders with the West; and the Berlin Wall was torn down. When Gorbachev did not respond with force, Czechoslovakia and Romania broke free, followed by Ukraine and Armenia in 1990, and then Turkmenistan and Tajikistan in 1991.

To outsiders, Gorbachev was a hero. He won a Nobel Peace Prize and was feted by foreign leaders. But at home, living standards fell and he wrestled with deep economic problems. Gorbachev struggled to hold the empire together as his ministers deserted him and the clamor for independence in the Baltic States became overwhelming. In July 1991, Boris Yeltsin was elected president of Russia and emerged as a champion of reform when he saved Gorbachev from a coup by hard-line opponents in August. That same month, Yeltsin ordered the Soviet Communist Party to cease its activities in Russia. The Soviet Union faced oblivion when Ukraine, Russia, and Belarus secretly planned to form a new union. His position untenable, on Christmas Day 1991, Gorbachev resigned as Soviet president. Of the 15 remaining Soviet republics, 12 became sovereign states, and the USSR passed into history.



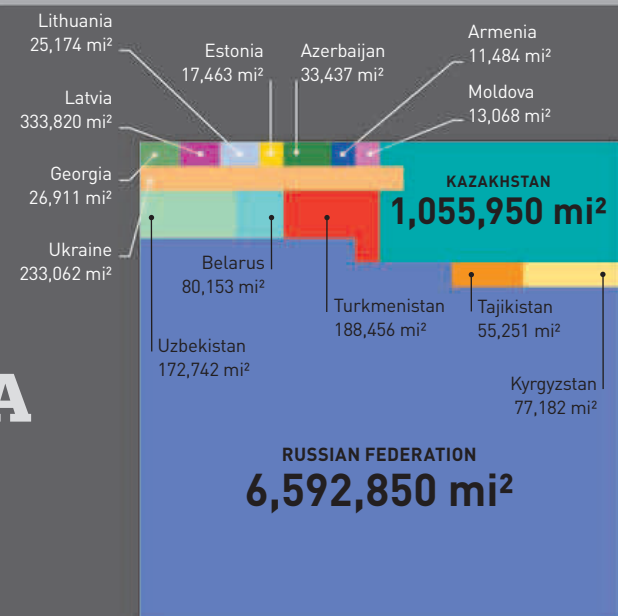
THE RISE AND FALL OF COMMUNISM

Communism was one of the most powerful political movements of the modern world, inspiring great thinkers and guerrilla fighters alike. It was supposed to offer ordinary people freedom from want and oppression, and it united Western critics of the capitalist system.

The great experiment, which began with the seizure of the Winter Palace in Petrograd in 1917, ended in 1989–91, as the Berlin Wall was torn down and the empire of the USSR came apart. China, Cuba, Vietnam, and North Korea still call themselves communist, yet the consensus is that, without the Soviet Union to hold it together, communism is at a dead end.

“UPON THE
SUCCESS OF
PERESTROIKA
DEPENDS THE
FUTURE OF
PEACE.”

Mikhail Gorbachev, Soviet statesman, 1987



Soviet dissolution

Territory that once belonged to the Soviet Union now forms a number of new states. By far the largest is the Russian Federation.